7 Days of DASH

GroceryList,SodiumSwaps&SimpleMeal Builder

A practicalway to explore DASH one meal, grocery choice, and habit at a time.

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Start with one useful change.

Evidence-informed education. Not individualized medical advice.

DASH at a glance

What is DASH?

DASHstandsfor Dietary Approaches toStop Hypertension. It was originally studied as a dietary pattern for blood-pressure reduction andisbuilt around everyday foods rather than a special product or strict meal plan.

DASH is a pattern - not a purity test.

Frozen vegetablescount.Cannedbeanscount.Affordablestorebrandscount.Restaurantmealsandculturally familiar foods can fit.

Generally emphasizes

- [ ] Vegetables and fruit
- [ ] Whole grains
- [ ] Beans and lentils
- [ ] Nuts and seeds
- [ ] Lower-fat dairy when appropriate
- [ ] Fish, poultry and lean proteins
- [ ] Vegetable oils and unsaturated fats

Generally limits

- [ ] Excessive sodium
- [ ] Foods high in saturated fat
- [ ] Heavily processed foods
- [ ] Sugar-sweetened beverages
- [ ] Frequent high-sodium foods
- [ ]

What the science says

Strongest evidence

Bloodpressure.Randomized trials consistently show DASH-style patterns can reduce blood pressure.

Supportive evidence

Cardiometabolic health. Research suggests potential improvements in LDL cholesterol, weight, or waist circumference in some groups.

More variable

Blood glucoseand insulin. DASH can fit diabetes care, but direct glucose and insulin effects are less consistent across trials.

Do not overstate glycemic benefits. Use DASH as a flexible framework, not a promise.

Build your DASH cart

Start at the grocery store



Vegetables

- [ ] Frozen vegetables
- [ ] Leafy greens
- [ ] Broccoli, carrots, peppers
- [ ] Tomatoes and onions
- [ ] No-salt-added canned vegetables

Fruit

- [ ] Apples, bananas, citrus
- [ ] Berries
- [ ] Seasonal fruit
- [ ] Frozen unsweetened fruit

Whole grains & fiber-rich carbohydrates

- [ ] Oats
- [ ] Brown rice
- [ ] Whole-grain bread or wraps
- [ ] Whole-grain pasta
- [ ] Potatoes or sweet potatoes
- [ ] Culturally familiar grains

Beans & lentils

- [ ] Black beans,chickpeas
- [ ] Lentils or kidney beans
- [ ] Other legumes
- [ ] Compare sodium or rinse canned beans

Protein

- [ ] Fish
- [ ] Chicken or turkey
- [ ] Eggs
- [ ] Beans/lentils
- [ ] Plain yogurt
- [ ] Lower-sodium canned fish

Nuts, seeds & fats

- [ ] Unsalted nuts
- [ ] Seeds
- [ ] Peanut or nut butter
- [ ] Olive oil
- [ ] Avocado

Flavor builders

- [ ] Garlic,lemon/lime
- [ ] Vinegar, pepper, herbs
- [ ] Paprika, cumin, chili
- [ ] Salt-free seasoning blends

Carbohydrates are not inherently unhealthy. For diabetes care, portions may need to be individualized.

Sodium swap lab

Don't memorize foods. Compare them.

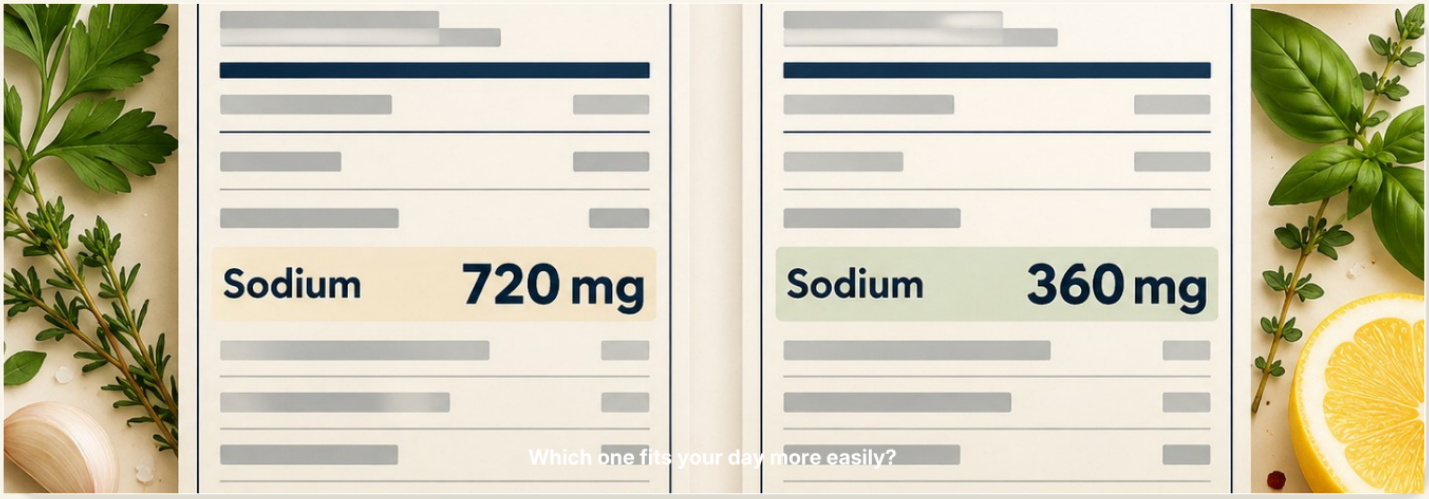
Muchof the sodiumpeople eat comes from packagedfoods,restaurantfoods,sauces,breads,delimeats, soups, snacks, and preparedmeals - notonly from thesaltshaker.

DASH sodium reference points

2,300 mg/day commonlyused standard DASH sodium limit

1,500 mg/day may lower blood pressure further for some people

These are reference levels - not individualized prescriptions. Yourmedicalneedsmay differ.



You do not need to declare one food good and the other bad. The point is to understand the tradeoff.

10 realistic sodium swaps

- [ ] Regular canned beans -> lower-sodium or rinsedbeans
- [ ] Regular broth -> reduced-sodium broth
- [ ] Heavy bottled sauce -> smaller portion or lower-sodium version
- [ ] Deli meat every day -> rotate with eggs, beans, tuna, leftovers
- [ ] Salt-heavy blend -> herbs + spices + citrus
- [ ] Salted nuts -> unsalted or lightly salted nuts
- [ ] Restaurant sauce poured over -> sauce on the side when practical
- [ ] Instant flavored grains -> plain grains + your own seasonings
- [ ] High-sodium frozen entree -> compare similar options
- [ ] Large sodium-heavy portion -> smaller serving + vegetables/protein

Build a DASH-friendly plate

Build the meal you already like

ADASH-friendlymealcanbeabowl,curry,taco,soup,sandwich,familyrecipe,or restaurant meal.



1. **Vegetables**
   Startwithvegetables when available.
2. **Protein**
   Beans,lentils, fish, poultry, eggs, yogurt, or another protein.
3. **Car bohydrate**
   Whole grains,potatoes, beans, fruit, bread, tortillas, rice, or staples thatfit.
4. **Flavor + healthy fats**
   Oliveoil,avocado,nuts,seeds, herbs, citrus, and spices.
5. **Beverage**
   Water,sparkling water, unsweetened tea, or lower-sugar options.

DASH is not inherently a low-carbohydrate diet.

For peoplewithdiabetes,carbohydrateamountandportionsmayneedtobeindividualized.

Four real-world DASH-style meals

Salmon bowl

Salmon + roasted vegetables + brown rice + yogurt sauce

Bean tacos

Beans + cabbage + tomato + avocado + corn tortillas

Chicken stir-fry

Chicken + vegetables + rice + herbs/spices

Lentil curry

Lentils + vegetables + whole grain or rice + yogurt

Choose a familiar meal. Add one useful DASH-related step.

Your 7-day starter

Seven days. Seven experiments.

1

Add a fruit

Add one fruit you genuinely enjoy to a meal or snack you already eat. Do not change anything else unless you want to.

2

Add a vegetable

Add one vegetable to a meal. Fresh, frozen, canned, cooked, raw, or leftover all count.

3

Compare a grain

Look at one grain or bread you buy. Compare fiber, sodium, and serving size.

4

Try beans or lentils

Use them in tacos, soup, salad, curry, rice, pasta, or a bowl. They do not have to replace meat completely.

5

Add nuts or seeds

Try walnuts, almonds, peanuts, pumpkin seeds, chia, or flax. Choose unsalted or lightly salted if appropriate.

6

Run a sodium experiment

Choose one food you buy frequently. Ask: How much sodium is in the amount I actually eat?

7

Build one complete meal

Try vegetables + protein + carbohydrate + satisfying flavor + lower-sugar beverage. Celebrate the practice.

You have not completed DASH.

You practiced seven useful DASH-related behaviors.

No judgment. Just information, practice, and one small next step.

Keep going + safety

What happens after Day 7?

Next habits to repeat

- [ ] Addvegetables to oneregular meal
- [ ] Compare sodium on one recurring food
- [ ] Eat beans or lentils once or twice per week
- [ ] Keep fruit somewhere easy to see
- [ ] Use herbs, citrus, vinegar and spices
- [ ] Build one DASH-style meal each week

When DASH may need individualization

Talkwith anappropriate healthcareprofessional or registereddietitian before intentionally increasing potassium intake or using potassium-based salt substitutes if you:

- [ ] have chronic kidney disease
- [ ] restrict potassium
- [ ] take medicines affecting potassium
- [ ] have sodium or fluid restrictions
- [ ] have other medical dietary requirements

If you live with diabetes

ADASH-style eating patterncan beadapted to diabetes care. There is no single DASH carbohydrate target that works for everyone. Carbohydrate quantity, meal timing, medication, activity, glucose response, culture, preferences, and other factors can influence what works best.

Never change prescribed medications based only on this guide.

Keep learning with Mindful Diabetes

Read the full DASH Diet guide
mindfuldiabetes.org/dash-diet/

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Scientific references

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Educational purposes only. This guide is not individualized medical advice and does not replace care from a qualified healthcare professional. Dietary needs can differ based on health conditions, medications, allergies, culture, access, and personal preferences.